

A 2-ADIC RIGIDITY AND AUTOMATA-THEORETIC FRAMEWORK FOR THE DICKSON–PILLAI PROBLEM IN WARING’S PROBLEM

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ABSTRACT. In Waring’s problem, the exact representation number $g(k) = 2^k + \lfloor (3/2)^k \rfloor - 2$ holds for all $k \geq 6$ if and only if the Dickson–Pillai condition $r_k + q_k \leq 2^k$ is satisfied, where $3^k = q_k 2^k + r_k$. Defining the Diophantine defect $D_k := 2^k - r_k = (q_k + 1)2^k - 3^k$, a failure occurs if and only if $D_k < q_k = \lfloor (3/2)^k \rfloor$, which demands an extreme Diophantine proximity $\|(3/2)^k\| < (3/4)^k = 2^{-\lambda_{\text{target}} k}$ with $\lambda_{\text{target}} = \log_2(4/3) \approx 0.415037$.

We develop a new local-to-global and automata-theoretic framework for the Dickson–Pillai problem, establishing exact 2-adic conservation laws, strict dynamical repulsion, and a formal reduction to the 2-adic digit complexity of $\ln_2 3$. We prove seven unconditional structural theorems: (1) For all $k \geq 3$, $D_k \bmod 8 \in \{5, 7\}$, which eliminates 75% of residue classes and unconditionally proves $D_k \notin \{1, 3\}$; (2) For even $k \geq 6$, the Lifting the Exponent Lemma (LTE) combined with the ultrametric property yields the exact valuation $v_2(D_k + 1) = v_2(k) + 2$; (3) For odd $k \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ ($k \geq 5$), the defect is locked to $D_k \equiv 5 \pmod{16}$ ($v_2(D_k + 3) = 3$), while for $k \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, $v_2(D_k + 3) = v_2(k - 1) + 2$; (4) The defect obeys the affine drift recurrence $3D_k - D_{k+1} = C_k 2^k$, where the multiplier $C_k = 3q_k - 2q_{k+1} + 1 \in \{-1, 0, 1, 2\}$ is governed by an explicit 4-state cylinder partition on $(\mathbb{Z}/2\mathbb{Z}) \times [0, 1)$; (5) Any hypothetical failure $D_k < q_k$ forces the fractional part $\delta_k > 1 - (3/4)^k > 2/3$, causing an immediate state collapse that strictly forbids $C_k \in \{1, 2\}$ and forces $C_k \in \{-1, 0\}$; (6) Under any failure index $k \geq 5$, discrete carry dynamics enforce strict isolation for even quotients (q_k even forces $C_k = -1 \implies D_{k+1} > 2^k > 2q_{k+1}$), while odd quotients (q_k odd forces $C_k = 0 \implies D_{k+1} = 3D_k$) trigger a geometric doubling of the safety ratio $\frac{D_{k+1}}{q_{k+1}} > 1.9 \frac{D_k}{q_k}$, strictly bounding consecutive failure runs; (7) Even failure indices satisfy an exact non-linear 2-adic fixed-point relation modulo $2^{k-v_2(k)-2}$ governed by the universal 2-adic constant $\nu := \frac{\ln_2 3}{4} \in \mathbb{Z}_2^\times$.

Furthermore, the carry transducer for binary multiplication by 3 emitting unbroken runs of ones has state transition matrix A with spectrum $\{0, 1, 1, -1\}$ (spectral radius $\rho = 1$), reflecting the periodic base-2 expansions of rational preimages. We delineate the exact Diophantine boundaries—including the Frey curve Szpiro ratio floor $\sigma \geq 5.26189$, reciprocal Hermite–Padé rank degeneracy over $\mathbb{Q}$, the Chebyshev clearing factor barrier $2.0934 > 2.0000$, and the 2-adic digit complexity reduction. Core algebraic and modular relations are formalized in Lean 4 with zero external axioms.

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1. INTRODUCTION AND PROBLEM FORMULATION

1.1. The Euler–Waring Formula and Dickson–Pillai Condition. For each integer $k \geq 1$, let $g(k)$ denote the minimal number s such that every positive integer can be written as the sum of at most s non-negative k -th powers. Following Hilbert’s qualitative existence theorem in 1909, Dickson [2] and Pillai [7] independently proved in 1936 that for all $k \geq 6$:

$$g(k) = 2^k + \left\lfloor \left(\frac{3}{2} \right)^k \right\rfloor - 2, \quad (1.1)$$

provided that the quotient $q_k = \lfloor (3/2)^k \rfloor$ and remainder $r_k = 3^k \bmod 2^k$ satisfy the *Dickson–Pillai condition*:

$$r_k + q_k \leq 2^k, \quad \text{where } 3^k = q_k 2^k + r_k \quad (0 \leq r_k < 2^k). \quad (1.2)$$

If this condition were to fail ($r_k + q_k > 2^k$), the formula for $g(k)$ would acquire additional terms depending on $\lfloor (4/3)^k \rfloor$, as investigated by Pillai [8], Rubugunday [9], and Niven [6].

1.2. The Diophantine Defect and Failure Envelope. Let the Diophantine *defect* D_k be defined by:

$$D_k := 2^k - r_k = (q_k + 1)2^k - 3^k. \quad (1.3)$$

The Dickson–Pillai condition (1.2) is equivalent to:

$$D_k \geq q_k. \quad (1.4)$$

A failure (counterexample) corresponds to an exponent k where $1 \leq D_k < q_k$. Since $q_k < (3/4)^k 2^k$, a failure index forces the distance from $(3/2)^k$ to the nearest integer to be extraordinarily small:

$$\left\| \left(\frac{3}{2} \right)^k \right\| < \left(\frac{3}{4} \right)^k = 2^{-\lambda_{\text{target}} k}, \quad \lambda_{\text{target}} = \log_2 \left(\frac{4}{3} \right) \approx 0.415037. \quad (1.5)$$

1.3. Status of the Art and The Analytic Exponent Gap. The theoretical landscape features a severe barrier:

- **Qualitative Finiteness (Mahler 1957):** Using Ridout’s p -adic extension of the Thue–Siegel–Roth theorem, Mahler [5] proved that only finitely many exceptions can exist. However, Roth’s method is ineffective, providing no computable bound K_0 .
- **Effective Linear Forms (Bennett 1994):** Using hypergeometric Padé approximants to $\sqrt{1-z}$ at $z = 1/9$, Bennett [1] established:

$$\left\| \left(\frac{3}{2} \right)^k \right\| > 2^{-\lambda_{\text{Bennett}} k}, \quad \text{with } \lambda_{\text{Bennett}} = 0.787. \quad (1.6)$$

Because $0.787 > 0.415037$, Bennett’s lower bound is weaker than the failure threshold $(3/4)^k$ and cannot rule out exceptions for any k .

- **Empirical Verification:** Kubina and Wunderlich [4] confirmed by arbitrary-precision computation that zero exceptions exist for all $k \leq 471,600,000$.

Method / Work	Technique / Invariant	Main Scope / Result	Effectivity
Mahler (1957) [5]	Ridout’s Theorem (p -adic Roth)	Finitely many exceptions	Ineffective
Bennett (1994) [1]	Hypergeometric Padé ($z = 1/9$)	$\ (3/2)^k\ > 2^{-0.787k}$ ($\lambda = 0.787$)	Effective
Kubina–Wunderlich (1990) [4]	Multi-precision FFT	Zero exceptions for $k \leq 4.71 \times 10^8$	Exhaustive
Present Work (Kerimov)	2-Adic LTE + Carry Recurrence & Dynamical Expansion	$D_k \bmod 8 \in \{5, 7\}$; exact $v_2(D_k + c)$; $C_k \in \{-1, 0\}$ under failure; $D_{k+1} > 2q_{k+1}$ (q_k even); ratio doubling (q_k odd); Reduction to $\nu \in \mathbb{Z}_2^\times$ complexity	Unconditional; formalized in Lean 4

TABLE 1. Comparative state of the art on the Dickson–Pillai problem in Waring’s problem.

Closing the exponent gap from 0.787 down to 0.415037 has remained open for nearly a century. In this work, we develop a new local-to-global and automata-theoretic framework, uncovering exact algebraic conservation laws in $\mathbb{Z}_2$, state collapses, and dynamical isolation and ratio expansion laws that restrict hypothetical counterexamples.

2. UNCONDITIONALLY PROVEN 2-ADIC STRUCTURAL THEOREMS

2.1. Theorem 1: Residue Exclusion Modulo 8.

Theorem 2.1 (Residue Exclusion Modulo 8). *For all $k \geq 3$, the Diophantine defect satisfies:*

$$D_k \bmod 8 = \begin{cases} 7 & \text{if } k \text{ is even,} \\ 5 & \text{if } k \text{ is odd.} \end{cases} \quad (2.1)$$

Proof. From $3^k = (q_k + 1)2^k - D_k$, reducing modulo 8 (noting $2^k \equiv 0 \pmod{8}$ for $k \geq 3$) yields:

$$D_k \equiv -3^k \pmod{8}.$$

By induction on k , $3^k \bmod 8$ alternates: $3^k \equiv 1 \pmod{8}$ for even k , and $3^k \equiv 3 \pmod{8}$ for odd k . Inverting modulo 8:

$$D_k \equiv -1 \equiv 7 \pmod{8} \quad (k \text{ even}), \quad D_k \equiv -3 \equiv 5 \pmod{8} \quad (k \text{ odd}). \quad \square$$

Corollary 2.2 (Elimination of Small Defects). *For all $k \geq 3$:*

- (1) D_k is strictly odd;
- (2) $D_k \neq 1$ and $D_k \neq 3$;
- (3) Exactly 75% of residue classes modulo 8 ($\{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 6\}$) are unconditionally excluded from ever being defect values.

2.2. Theorem 2: Exact 2-Adic Valuation for Even Indices ($k = 2m$).

Theorem 2.3 (Even Index 2-Adic Rigidity). *For every even integer $k = 2m$ with $k \geq 6$:*

$$v_2(D_k + 1) = v_2(k) + 2. \quad (2.2)$$

Equivalently, D_k terminates in exactly $v_2(k) + 2$ consecutive ones in binary:

$$D_k = 2^{v_2(k)+2}W - 1, \quad \text{with } W \text{ odd}. \quad (2.3)$$

Proof. For $k = 2m$, we factor $3^k - 1 = 9^m - 1 = (8 + 1)^m - 1 = 8V_m$, where $V_m := \sum_{\ell=0}^{m-1} 9^\ell$. By the Lifting the Exponent Lemma (LTE) for $p = 2$:

$$v_2(9^m - 1) = v_2(9 - 1) + v_2(m) = 3 + v_2(m) = 3 + (v_2(k) - 1) = v_2(k) + 2.$$

From the defect identity, adding 1 to both sides yields:

$$D_k + 1 = (q_k + 1)2^k - (9^m - 1) = (q_k + 1)2^k - 8V_m.$$

The first term $A = (q_k + 1)2^k$ has 2-adic valuation $v_2(A) \geq k$. For all even $k \geq 6$, $k > v_2(k) + 2$ (since $v_2(k) \leq \log_2 k < k - 2$). By the non-Archimedean ultrametric property ($v_2(A - B) = \min(v_2(A), v_2(B))$) whenever $v_2(A) \neq v_2(B)$:

$$v_2(D_k + 1) = \min(v_2(A), v_2(9^m - 1)) = v_2(9^m - 1) = v_2(k) + 2. \quad \square$$

2.3. Theorem 3: Exact 2-Adic Valuation for Odd Indices ($k = 2m + 1$).

Theorem 2.4 (Odd Index 2-Adic Rigidity).

- (1) *For all $k \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ with $k \geq 5$:*

$$v_2(D_k + 3) = 3 \iff D_k \equiv 5 \pmod{16}. \quad (2.4)$$

- (2) *For all $k \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$ with $k \geq 5$:*

$$v_2(D_k + 3) = v_2(k - 1) + 2. \quad (2.5)$$

Proof. Writing $k = 2m + 1$, we have:

$$D_k + 3 = (q_k + 1)2^k - (3 \cdot 9^m - 3) = (q_k + 1)2^k - 24V_m.$$

Dividing by 8:

$$\frac{D_k + 3}{8} = (q_k + 1)2^{k-3} - 3V_m.$$

When $k \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, m is odd. Then $V_m = \sum_{\ell=0}^{m-1} 9^\ell \equiv m \cdot 1 \equiv 1 \pmod{2}$. For $k \geq 5$, $k - 3 \geq 2$, so $(q_k + 1)2^{k-3}$ is even while $3V_m$ is odd. Hence $(D_k + 3)/8$ is odd, establishing $v_2(D_k + 3) = 3$. When $k \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, $m = (k - 1)/2$ is even, so $v_2(V_m) = v_2(m) = v_2(k - 1) - 1$. Then $v_2(24V_m) = 3 + v_2(m) = v_2(k - 1) + 2$. Since $k \geq 5$, $k > v_2(k - 1) + 2$ (because $v_2(k - 1) \leq \log_2(k - 1) < k - 2$). By the ultrametric property, $v_2(D_k + 3) = v_2(k - 1) + 2$. $\square$

3. DISCRETE CARRY DRIFT RECURRENCE AND CYLINDER STATE PARTITIONS

3.1. Theorem 4: The 4-State Carry Drift Recurrence.

Theorem 3.1 (Discrete Carry Drift Recurrence). *For all $k \geq 1$:*

$$3D_k - D_{k+1} = C_k 2^k \iff D_{k+1} = 3D_k - C_k 2^k, \quad (3.1)$$

where the multiplier $C_k := 3q_k - 2q_{k+1} + 1$ satisfies $C_k \in \{-1, 0, 1, 2\}$, governed explicitly by the cylinder partition on $(q_k \bmod 2, \delta_k)$, where $\delta_k = \{(3/2)^k\} = r_k/2^k$:

$$C_k = \begin{cases} 1 & \text{if } q_k \text{ is even and } \delta_k \in [0, 2/3), \\ -1 & \text{if } q_k \text{ is even and } \delta_k \in [2/3, 1), \\ 2 & \text{if } q_k \text{ is odd and } \delta_k \in [0, 1/3), \\ 0 & \text{if } q_k \text{ is odd and } \delta_k \in [1/3, 1). \end{cases} \quad (3.2)$$

Proof. Substituting $D_k = (q_k + 1)2^k - 3^k$ and $D_{k+1} = (q_{k+1} + 1)2^{k+1} - 3^{k+1}$:

$$3D_k - D_{k+1} = [3(q_k + 1) - 2(q_{k+1} + 1)]2^k = [3q_k - 2q_{k+1} + 1]2^k = C_k 2^k.$$

To deduce the four states, express $q_{k+1} = \lfloor \frac{3}{2}(q_k + \delta_k) \rfloor = \lfloor \frac{3}{2}q_k + \frac{3}{2}\delta_k \rfloor$:

(1) If $q_k = 2m$ is even:

$$q_{k+1} = 3m + \left\lfloor \frac{3}{2}\delta_k \right\rfloor = \begin{cases} 3m & \text{if } \delta_k < 2/3, \\ 3m + 1 & \text{if } \delta_k \geq 2/3. \end{cases}$$

Then $C_k = 3(2m) - 2q_{k+1} + 1 = 6m - 2q_{k+1} + 1$. When $\delta_k < 2/3$, $C_k = 6m - 6m + 1 = 1$.
When $\delta_k \geq 2/3$, $C_k = 6m - 2(3m + 1) + 1 = -1$.

(2) If $q_k = 2m + 1$ is odd:

$$q_{k+1} = \left\lfloor 3m + \frac{3}{2} + \frac{3}{2}\delta_k \right\rfloor = 3m + 1 + \left\lfloor \frac{1}{2} + \frac{3}{2}\delta_k \right\rfloor = \begin{cases} 3m + 1 & \text{if } \delta_k < 1/3, \\ 3m + 2 & \text{if } \delta_k \geq 1/3. \end{cases}$$

Then $C_k = 3(2m+1) - 2q_{k+1} + 1 = 6m + 4 - 2q_{k+1}$. When $\delta_k < 1/3$, $C_k = 6m + 4 - 2(3m + 1) = 2$. When $\delta_k \geq 1/3$, $C_k = 6m + 4 - 2(3m + 2) = 0$. $\square$

3.2. Theorem 5: State Collapse Under Failure.

Theorem 3.2 (State Collapse Under Failure). *If $k \geq 5$ is a failure index ($D_k < q_k$), then:*

$$\delta_k > 1 - \left(\frac{3}{4}\right)^k > \frac{2}{3}. \quad (3.3)$$

Consequently, the states $C_k = 1$ and $C_k = 2$ are strictly forbidden, and any failure index forces:

$$C_k \in \{-1, 0\}. \quad (3.4)$$

Proof. By definition, $D_k = 2^k(1 - \delta_k)$. Under failure, $D_k < q_k < (3/2)^k$, which yields:

$$1 - \delta_k < \left(\frac{3}{4}\right)^k \implies \delta_k > 1 - \left(\frac{3}{4}\right)^k.$$

For $k \geq 5$, $(3/4)^k \leq (3/4)^5 = 243/1024 < 1/4 < 1/3$. Thus $\delta_k > 1 - 1/3 = 2/3$. Referring to Theorem 3.1:

- $C_k = 1$ requires $\delta_k < 2/3$ (contradiction);
- $C_k = 2$ requires $\delta_k < 1/3$ (contradiction).

Therefore, only $C_k = -1$ (if q_k is even) or $C_k = 0$ (if q_k is odd) can occur. $\square$

4. DYNAMICAL ISOLATION, RATIO EXPANSION, AND 2-ADIC REDUCTION

4.1. Theorem 6: Dynamical Isolation and Ratio Expansion.

Theorem 4.1 (Dynamical Isolation and Ratio Expansion). *Let $k \geq 5$ be a hypothetical failure index ($D_k < q_k$). Then the discrete carry dynamics at step $k+1$ satisfy:*

- (1) **Even Quotient Isolation:** *If q_k is even, then $C_k = -1$ unconditionally forces:*

$$D_{k+1} > 2^k > 2q_{k+1}. \quad (4.1)$$

In particular, step $k+1$ is strictly immune from failure.

- (2) **Odd Quotient Geometric Doubling:** *If q_k is odd, then $C_k = 0$, $D_{k+1} = 3D_k$, and the safety ratio expands geometrically:*

$$\frac{D_{k+1}}{q_{k+1}} = \frac{6D_k}{3q_k + 1} \geq \frac{6}{3 + 1/q_k} \frac{D_k}{q_k} > 1.9 \frac{D_k}{q_k}. \quad (4.2)$$

- (3) **Run Length Bound:** *If $q_k \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, then $q_{k+1} = \frac{3q_k+1}{2}$ is even, so any failure chain starting at k has length at most 2. More generally, any consecutive sequence of failures must have strictly odd quotients and can persist for at most $\lceil \log_2(q_k/D_k) \rceil$ steps before the geometric expansion forces an exit from the failure zone or triggers an even quotient.*

Proof. Let $k \geq 5$ be a failure index. By Theorem 3.2, $C_k \in \{-1, 0\}$.

- (1) **Branch 1** (q_k even $\implies C_k = -1$): By the recurrence (3.1):

$$D_{k+1} = 3D_k - (-1)2^k = 3D_k + 2^k > 2^k.$$

Since $q_{k+1} = \lfloor (3/2)^{k+1} \rfloor = \lfloor (3/4)^{k+1} 2^{k+1} \rfloor$, and for all $k \geq 5$:

$$2 \left(\frac{3}{4} \right)^{k+1} \leq 2 \left(\frac{3}{4} \right)^6 = 2 \cdot \frac{729}{4096} < \frac{1}{2},$$

we have $q_{k+1} < \frac{1}{2} 2^k \implies 2^k > 2q_{k+1}$. Hence $D_{k+1} > 2^k > 2q_{k+1}$, strictly isolating the failure.

- (2) **Branch 2** (q_k odd $\implies C_k = 0$): Here $D_{k+1} = 3D_k$. Since q_k is odd and $\delta_k > 2/3 \geq 1/3$, by Theorem 3.1 we have $q_{k+1} = \frac{3q_k+1}{2}$. Then the safety ratio satisfies:

$$\frac{D_{k+1}}{q_{k+1}} = \frac{3D_k}{(3q_k + 1)/2} = \frac{6D_k}{3q_k + 1} = \frac{2}{1 + 1/(3q_k)} \frac{D_k}{q_k}.$$

For $k \geq 5$, $q_k \geq 7$, so $\frac{2}{1+1/(3q_k)} \geq \frac{42}{22} \approx 1.909 > 1.9$.

- (3) **Run Length Bound:** If $q_k \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, write $q_k = 4m + 1$. Then $q_{k+1} = \frac{3(4m+1)+1}{2} = 6m + 2 = 2(3m + 1)$ is even. If step $k+1$ were also a failure, then because q_{k+1} is even, Branch 1 would apply to step $k+1$, unconditionally forcing $D_{k+2} > 2q_{k+2}$, terminating the run after at most 2 steps. In general, if a run of consecutive failures persists for j steps, each quotient $q_{k+\ell}$ ($\ell < j$) must be odd, so the defect ratio expands as $\frac{D_{k+j}}{q_{k+j}} \geq (1.9)^j \frac{D_k}{q_k}$. For $k+j$ to remain a failure, we require $\frac{D_{k+j}}{q_{k+j}} < 1$, which imposes $j < \frac{\ln(q_k/D_k)}{\ln 1.9} \leq \lceil \log_2(q_k/D_k) \rceil$. $\square$

Remark 4.2 (Dynamical Drift vs. Failure Trajectories). Theorem 4.1 establishes that the failure zone is dynamically unstable: even-quotient failures are immediately and permanently expelled ($D_{k+1} > 2q_{k+1}$), while odd-quotient failures undergo rapid geometric doubling of their defect ratio, precluding long consecutive chains of failures.

4.2. Theorem 7: Universal 2-Adic Fixed-Point Reduction ($\nu = \frac{\ln_2 3}{4}$).

Theorem 4.3 (Universal 2-Adic Non-Linear Fixed-Point Reduction). *Let $\nu := \frac{\ln_2 3}{4} \in \mathbb{Z}_2^\times$ denote the universal 2-adic constant. For every even integer $k = 2^{v_2(k)}u \geq 6$ (with u odd), the integer defect parameter $W := \frac{D_k+1}{2^{v_2(k)+2}}$ satisfies:*

- (1) **Exact Non-Linear Congruence:** *Modulo $2^{k-v_2(k)-2}$, W satisfies the exact identity:*

$$u\nu + W + \sum_{j=2}^{\infty} \frac{2^{(j-1)(v_2(k)+2)}}{j} W^j \equiv 0 \pmod{2^{k-v_2(k)-2}}, \quad (4.3)$$

or equivalently, in 2-adic analytic ball notation:

$$\left| \frac{\ln_2(1 - 2^{v_2(k)+2}W)}{2^{v_2(k)+2}} - u\nu \right|_2 \leq 2^{-(k-v_2(k)-2)}. \quad (4.4)$$

- (2) **First-Order Linear Approximation:** *Modulo $2^{v_2(k)+1}$, the higher-order terms vanish, yielding:*

$$(-u \cdot \nu) \equiv W \pmod{2^{v_2(k)+1}}. \quad (4.5)$$

- (3) **Rational Reconstruction under Failure:** *Under a hypothetical failure $D_k < q_k$, we have $W < \frac{1}{8}(3/2)^k$. When $v_2(k) \geq \frac{1}{2}k \log_2(3/2)$, the modulus $2^{v_2(k)+1}$ satisfies $2^{v_2(k)+1} > 2uW$, and the pair (u, W) is uniquely determined as a convergent of ν via the Wang–Guy–Davenport rational reconstruction theorem. Conversely, for generic even k where $v_2(k)$ is small (e.g., $k \equiv 2 \pmod{4}$ with $v_2(k) = 1$), the first-order modulus is $2^2 = 4$; however, the full non-linear identity (4.3) maintains high precision modulo $2^{k-v_2(k)-2}$, defining W as an isolated non-linear 2-adic fixed point.*

Proof. From $3^k = (q_k + 1)2^k - D_k$, reducing modulo 2^k gives $3^k \equiv -D_k \pmod{2^k}$. By Theorem 2.3, for even k :

$$D_k = 2^{v_2(k)+2}W - 1 \implies -D_k = 1 - 2^{v_2(k)+2}W.$$

Applying the 2-adic logarithm power series $\ln_2(1 - x) = -\sum_{j=1}^{\infty} \frac{x^j}{j} = -x - \sum_{j=2}^{\infty} \frac{x^j}{j}$ (noting that because the argument is $1 - x$, all terms have strictly negative signs) with $x = 2^{v_2(k)+2}W$:

$$k \ln_2 3 \equiv -2^{v_2(k)+2}W - \sum_{j=2}^{\infty} \frac{(2^{v_2(k)+2}W)^j}{j} \pmod{2^k}.$$

Writing $k = 2^{v_2(k)}u$ and $\ln_2 3 = 4\nu$, the left-hand side is $2^{v_2(k)+2}u\nu$. Dividing both sides by $2^{v_2(k)+2}$ in $\mathbb{Q}_2$ gives:

$$u\nu \equiv -W - \sum_{j=2}^{\infty} \frac{2^{(j-1)(v_2(k)+2)}}{j} W^j \pmod{2^{k-v_2(k)-2}}.$$

Transposing all terms to the left-hand side makes all coefficients positive:

$$u\nu + W + \sum_{j=2}^{\infty} \frac{2^{(j-1)(v_2(k)+2)}}{j} W^j \equiv 0 \pmod{2^{k-v_2(k)-2}},$$

which proves (4.3) and (4.4). For the valuation of the higher-order terms ($j \geq 2$):

$$v_2 \left(\frac{2^{(j-1)(v_2(k)+2)}}{j} W^j \right) = (j-1)(v_2(k)+2) - v_2(j).$$

For $j = 2$, this valuation is $(2-1)(v_2(k)+2) - 1 = v_2(k) + 1$. For $j \geq 3$, $(j-1)(v_2(k)+2) - v_2(j) \geq 2(v_2(k)+2) - \log_2 j > v_2(k) + 1$. Thus, reducing modulo $2^{v_2(k)+1}$ eliminates all terms with $j \geq 2$, yielding the linear congruence $(-u \cdot \nu) \equiv W \pmod{2^{v_2(k)+1}}$. Finally, under failure, $D_k < q_k \leq (3/2)^k$,

so $W = \frac{D_k+1}{2^{v_2(k)+2}} < \frac{1}{8}(3/2)^k$. If $2^{v_2(k)+1} > 2uW$, Wang–Guy–Davenport applies directly to the linear congruence. Otherwise, the full non-linear identity (4.3) preserves the full $2^{k-v_2(k)-2}$ constraint. $\square$

5. AUTOMATA-THEORETIC AND FUNCTIONAL-ANALYTIC DYNAMICS

5.1. The Carry Transducer Subshift and Zero Topological Entropy. Multiplication of an integer by $3 = (11)_2$ in base 2 is executed by the elementary carry automaton:

$$a_j + a_{j-1} + c_j = 2c_{j+1} + y_j,$$

where $a_j \in \{0, 1\}$ are the bits of the input, $c_j \in \{0, 1\}$ is the carry bit, and $y_j \in \{0, 1\}$ is the emitted bit. Ordering the automaton states (a_{j-1}, c_j) as $1 = (0, 0)$, $2 = (0, 1)$, $3 = (1, 0)$, and $4 = (1, 1)$, we examine valid transitions emitting $y_j = 1$. Under this constraint, each state admits a unique input bit a_j : state 1 transitions to 3, states 2 and 3 transition to 1, and state 4 transitions to itself. The corresponding transition matrix $A = (A_{i,j})$, where $A_{i,j} = 1$ denotes an admissible transition from state i to state j , is:

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (5.1)$$

Proposition 5.1 (Spectral Properties of the Carry Automaton). *The transition matrix A satisfies:*

- (1) $\det(A) = 0$ and $\text{Tr}(A) = 1$;
- (2) *Characteristic polynomial:*

$$P_A(\lambda) = \det(A - \lambda I) = -\lambda(1 - \lambda)^2(1 + \lambda) = -\lambda^4 + \lambda^3 + \lambda^2 - \lambda; \quad (5.2)$$

- (3) *Spectrum:* $\text{Spec}(A) = \{0, 1, 1, -1\}$;
- (4) *Spectral radius:* $\rho(A) = 1$;
- (5) *Topological entropy of the subshift:*

$$h_{\text{top}}(\Sigma_A) = \log_2 \rho(A) = 0. \quad (5.3)$$

Proof. Direct expansion of $\det(A - \lambda I)$:

$$\det \begin{pmatrix} -\lambda & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & -\lambda & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & -\lambda & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 - \lambda \end{pmatrix} = (1 - \lambda) \det \begin{pmatrix} -\lambda & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & -\lambda & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & -\lambda \end{pmatrix} = (1 - \lambda)(-\lambda^3 + \lambda) = -\lambda(1 - \lambda)^2(1 + \lambda).$$

The eigenvalues are $\{0, 1, 1, -1\}$, giving $\rho(A) = 1$ and $h_{\text{top}}(\Sigma_A) = 0$. $\square$

Remark 5.2 (Combinatorial Complexity of Preimages). The condition $h_{\text{top}}(\Sigma_A) = 0$ carries a precise combinatorial meaning: the number $N(m)$ of valid input binary words of length m that emit an unbroken block of m consecutive ones grows at most polynomially (specifically, $N(m) \leq Cm$) rather than exponentially (2^{hm} with $h > 0$). The language of preimages generating continuous ones is strictly degenerate.

5.2. The Transfer Operator on the $\beta = 3/2$ Shift. The normalized defect $x_k = D_k/2^k \in [0, 1]$ is modeled by the expanding piecewise-affine map $T : [0, 1] \rightarrow [0, 1]$:

$$T(x) = \frac{3}{2}x \bmod 1.$$

The associated Perron–Frobenius transfer operator $\mathcal{L} : BV([0, 1]) \rightarrow BV([0, 1])$ acts by:

$$(\mathcal{L}f)(x) = \frac{2}{3}f\left(\frac{2}{3}x\right) + \frac{2}{3}f\left(\frac{2}{3}x + \frac{2}{3}\right) \cdot \mathbf{1}_{[0, 1/2]}(x).$$

By the Ionescu-Tulcea and Marinescu theorem:

- The essential spectral radius is bounded by $r_{\text{ess}}(\mathcal{L}) \leq 2/3$;
- The operator has a spectral gap: $\text{Spec}(\mathcal{L}) \setminus \{1\} \subset \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| \leq 2/3\}$;
- The failure holes $H_k = [0, (3/4)^k)$ satisfy $\sum_{k=1}^{\infty} \mu(H_k) \leq \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} (3/4)^k = 3 < \infty$.

By the Borel–Cantelli lemma, the set of exceptional orbits has Lebesgue measure zero and Hausdorff dimension zero.

Remark 5.3 (Diophantine Specificity vs. Generic Orbits). While the transfer operator and the Borel–Cantelli lemma establish that almost every initial point $x \in [0, 1]$ enters the shrinking target holes only finitely often, the Dickson–Pillai problem concerns the deterministic trajectory of the single algebraic initial point $x_0 = 1$ under $T(x) = \frac{3}{2}x \bmod 1$. As with Mahler’s 3/2 problem, generic measure-theoretic avoidance does not resolve individual algebraic initial conditions, highlighting the necessity of arithmetic methods.

6. ANALYSIS OF ATTEMPTED PROOF EXTENSIONS AND STRUCTURAL BARRIERS

6.1. Barrier 1: The Frey Curve and the Szpiro Bound. Associating the ternary partition $r_k + 2^k q_k = 3^k$ to the Frey–Hellegouarch elliptic curve:

$$E_k : y^2 = x(x - r_k)(x + 2^k q_k),$$

a failure $D_k < q_k$ forces the minimal discriminant to scale as $\ln |\Delta(E_k)| \sim (2 \ln 2 + 4 \ln 3)k \approx 5.78074k$, while the conductor is bounded by $\ln N(E_k) \leq k \ln 3 + \ln 12 \approx 1.09861k + 2.485$. This forces an asymptotic Szpiro ratio floor:

$$\sigma_{\text{fail}}(k) \geq \frac{5.78074}{1.09861} \approx 5.26189. \quad (6.1)$$

However, the best unconditional modular degree bound (Hoffstein–Lockhart [3]) yields only $\ln |\Delta| \leq 12 \ln N$ ($\sigma \leq 12$). Closing this gap requires an effective version of the *abc* conjecture over $\mathbb{Q}$.

6.2. Barrier 2: Reciprocal Hermite–Padé Rank Degeneracy over $\mathbb{Q}$. Attempting simultaneous Padé approximation to $f_1(z) = (1 - z)^{1/2}$ and $f_2(z) = (1 - z)^{-1/2}$ at $z = 1/9$:

$$f_1(1/9) = \sqrt{8/9} = \frac{2\sqrt{2}}{3}, \quad f_2(1/9) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{8/9}} = \frac{3\sqrt{2}}{4}.$$

These two values are linearly dependent over $\mathbb{Q}$:

$$3f_1(1/9) - \frac{8}{3}f_2(1/9) = 3 \left(\frac{2\sqrt{2}}{3} \right) - \frac{8}{3} \left(\frac{3\sqrt{2}}{4} \right) = 2\sqrt{2} - 2\sqrt{2} = 0.$$

The simultaneous Padé matrix drops rank over $\mathbb{Q}$, collapsing the system back to Bennett’s single-variable exponent $\lambda = 0.787$.

6.3. Barrier 3: The Asymmetric Padé Remainder vs. Chebyshev Denominator. Evaluating off-diagonal Padé approximants to $\ln(1 + x)$ at $x = 8$ with degree $n = \lfloor k/3 \rfloor$ yields a 2-adic divisibility lower bound:

$$|\Delta_n|_2 \leq 2^{-k} \implies |\Delta_n| \geq \frac{1}{2k} 2^k \quad (\text{growth base } 2.0000).$$

However, clearing rational coefficients requires multiplying by $d_n = \text{lcm}(1, \dots, n) \sim e^n \approx (e^{1/3})^k \approx (1.3956)^k$. Combined with the defect height $W < (1.5)^k$, the upper bound base is:

$$1.5 \times 1.3956 = \mathbf{2.0934} > \mathbf{2.0000}. \quad (6.2)$$

Because $2.0934 > 2.0000$, the Chebyshev denominator penalty overwhelms the 2-adic divisibility gain, preserving the linear form height gap.

6.4. Barrier 4: The Archimedean vs. 2-Adic Size Leakage. The exact 2-adic valuation $v_2(D_k + 1) = v_2(k) + 2$ constrains only the lowest $v_2(k) + 3 \leq \log_2 k + 3$ bits of D_k . The failure region $D_k < q_k$ spans $\approx k \log_2(1.5) \approx 0.585k$ bits. The danger window contains:

$$N_{\text{cand}}(k) \asymp \frac{(1.5)^k}{8k} \rightarrow \infty \quad (6.3)$$

integers that satisfy the exact 2-adic valuation formula. Purely non-Archimedean 2-adic methods cannot eliminate these high-order bits without Diophantine transcendence input.

6.5. Barrier 5: Carry Transducer Inversion and the 2-Adic Digit Complexity Barrier.

An attractive approach to closing the Archimedean gap is to invert the scalar carry transducer T_u executing multiplication by $u = k/2^{v_2(k)}$ on the 2-adic bits of $\nu = \frac{\ln_2 3}{4}$.

Under a hypothetical failure $D_k < q_k$, the top $L \geq \lambda_{\text{target}}k - \log_2 k$ bits of $u \cdot \nu \pmod{2^M}$ (where $M = k - v_2(k) - 2$) must terminate in an unbroken monochromatic run of ones 1^L . The iterated carry transducer equation across a window of length L yields:

$$u \cdot B \equiv -(\gamma_{M-L} + 1) \pmod{2^L}, \quad (6.4)$$

where $B = \sum_{\ell=0}^{L-1} c_{M-L+\ell} 2^\ell$ represents the input slice of bits from ν , and $\gamma_{M-L} \in \{0, 1, \dots, u-1\}$ is the accumulated carry into position $M-L$.

While equation (6.4) connects the Diophantine failure to the binary subwords of ν , it encounters three fundamental Diophantine obstructions:

- (1) **Sub-Periodic Window** ($\pi(u) > L$): The rational fraction $-(\gamma_{M-L} + 1)/u$ has 2-adic period $\pi(u) = \text{ord}_u(2)$. For generic odd $u \approx k$, $\pi(u) \asymp u \approx k$. Because $L \approx 0.415k < k \approx \pi(u)$, the window L is strictly shorter than a single full period, precluding internal periodicity collapse.
- (2) **Unconstrained Intermediate Carry**: The carry γ_{M-L} accumulates through $M-L \approx 0.585k$ preceding multiplication steps. In general, $\gamma_{M-L} \neq 0$, introducing an unconstrained degree of freedom.
- (3) **Non-Triviality of 2-Adic Digit Complexity**: Bounding the length of rational subwords in ν by $\mathcal{O}(\ln k)$ would require a deep theorem on the subword complexity or irrationality measure of 2-adic logarithmic series (e.g., resolving the 2-adic analogue of Borel's normality conjecture). Currently, bounding the run-length of digits in $\nu = \frac{\ln_2 3}{4}$ remains an open problem.

Definition 6.1 (Windowed Transducer Run Length). For any odd integer $u \geq 1$ and bit-precision $M \geq 1$, let $L(u, M)$ denote the maximal length of an unbroken monochromatic run of ones 1^L occurring in the M -bit binary prefix $(u \cdot \nu) \pmod{2^M}$, where $\nu = \frac{\ln_2 3}{4} \in \mathbb{Z}_2^\times$.

Proposition 6.2 (Qualitative Finiteness via Sublinear Window Complexity). *Let $\lambda_{\text{target}} = \log_2(4/3) \approx 0.415037$. Suppose there exists a constant $c < \lambda_{\text{target}}$ such that for all odd integers $u \geq 1$ and all sufficiently large window lengths M , the maximal run-length of continuous ones satisfies:*

$$L(u, M) \leq c \cdot M. \quad (6.5)$$

Then there are at most finitely many counterexamples to the Dickson–Pillai condition.

Proof. Suppose k is a failure index. Then $D_k < q_k < (3/4)^k 2^k = 2^{-\lambda_{\text{target}}k} 2^k$. By definition of $D_k = 2^k - r_k$, this forces $r_k = 3^k \pmod{2^k} > (1 - 2^{-\lambda_{\text{target}}k}) 2^k$, which means that the binary expansion of r_k terminates in an unbroken monochromatic run of ones of length:

$$L_k \geq \lambda_{\text{target}}k - \log_2 k.$$

For even failure indices $k = 2^{v_2(k)}u$, Theorem 4.3 connects r_k to the 2-adic expansion of $u\nu$ across the window of length $M_k = k - v_2(k) - 2 \leq k$. If hypothesis (6.5) holds across all windows M , then

the run-length in this window satisfies:

$$L(u, M_k) \leq c \cdot M_k \leq c \cdot k.$$

Equating run-lengths via the carry transducer inversion yields:

$$\lambda_{\text{target}}k - \log_2 k \leq L_k \leq L(u, M_k) + \mathcal{O}(v_2(k)) \leq ck + \mathcal{O}(\log_2 k).$$

Since $c < \lambda_{\text{target}}$, we obtain $(\lambda_{\text{target}} - c)k \leq \mathcal{O}(\log_2 k)$, which holds for only finitely many values of k , regardless of the size of the odd part $u = k/2^{v_2(k)}$. For odd failure indices $k = 2m + 1$, an exact analogue applies: factoring $3^k = 3 \cdot 9^m = 3 \exp_2(2m \ln_2 3) = 3 \exp_2(8m\nu)$ and reducing modulo 2^k yields $3 \exp_2(8m\nu) \equiv -D_k \pmod{2^k}$, which imposes an identical monochromatic suffix condition on the windowed expansion of $m\nu$ (where $m = (k - 1)/2$ and $v_2(D_k + 3)$ is governed by Theorem 2.4). Furthermore, Theorem 4.1 guarantees that any sequence of consecutive failures terminates in bounded steps via ratio doubling. Thus, the set of counterexamples is strictly finite. $\square$

Theorem 6.3 (Conditional Effective Elimination for All $k \geq 2$). *Suppose there exists an effective threshold $M_0 \leq K_{\text{comp}} - \lfloor \log_2 K_{\text{comp}} \rfloor - 2$ (e.g., $M_0 \leq 471,599,900$, where $K_{\text{comp}} = 471,600,000$ is the Kubina–Wunderlich bound) such that for all odd integers $u \geq 1$ and all window lengths $M \geq M_0$, the maximal run-length of continuous ones satisfies:*

$$L(u, M) < \lambda_{\text{target}}M - \log_2 M, \quad \text{where } \lambda_{\text{target}} = \log_2(4/3). \quad (6.6)$$

Then, combined with the computational verification of Kubina and Wunderlich [4], the Dickson–Pillai condition holds for all $k \geq 2$ with zero exceptions.

Proof. By Kubina and Wunderlich [4], no counterexamples exist for $2 \leq k \leq K_{\text{comp}} = 471,600,000$. For any candidate failure $k > K_{\text{comp}}$, the associated window length is $M_k = k - v_2(k) - 2$. Since $v_2(k) \leq \lfloor \log_2 k \rfloor$, we have:

$$M_k \geq k - \lfloor \log_2 k \rfloor - 2 \geq (K_{\text{comp}} + 1) - \lfloor \log_2(K_{\text{comp}} + 1) \rfloor - 2 \geq M_0.$$

If hypothesis (6.6) holds for all windows $M \geq M_0$, then the required failure run-length $L_k \geq \lambda_{\text{target}}k - \log_2 k \geq \lambda_{\text{target}}M_k - \log_2 M_k$ strictly exceeds $L(u, M_k)$, creating a contradiction. Hence no exceptions can exist for any $k \geq 2$. $\square$

7. HIGH-PERFORMANCE COMPUTATIONAL VERIFICATION ALGORITHM

The structural theorems yield an accelerated verification pipeline for $k > 10^9$:

- (1) **The Double-Precision Pre-Filter:** By Theorem 3.2, any index with $\delta_k < 2/3$ cannot be a failure. Tracking $\delta_k = \{(3/2)^k\}$ via rolling 64-bit fixed-point arithmetic prunes $\approx 66.7\%$ of candidate indices with zero arbitrary-precision integer operations.
- (2) **The 2-Adic Static Constant Scan:** By Theorem 4.3, verifying even indices k does not require computing $3^k \bmod 2^k$. Pre-computing the static binary expansion of $\nu = \frac{\ln_2 3}{4}$ transforms verification into a sliding-window binary pattern match against $u \leq k$.

8. LEAN 4 FORMAL VERIFICATION SUMMARY

All algebraic division identities, residue exclusions modulo 8 for all $k \geq 3$, small defect exclusions ($D_k \neq 1, 3$), and the discrete carry drift recurrence $3D_k - D_{k+1} = C_k 2^k$ for all $k \in \mathbb{N}$ have been formalized in Lean 4 with universal proofs in the companion module `formalization/TwoAdicDefectRigidity.lean`.¹ The formalization compiles with zero errors, zero warnings, and zero unproven axioms (relying only on standard Lean core axioms: `propext`, `Quot.sound`, and `Classical.choice`).

¹Full source code and Lean 4 verification suites are available in the dedicated repository: <https://github.com/KerimovEmil/DicksonPillai> (release tag v1.0.0).

In the accompanying Lean 4 repository, universal algebraic theorems (the residue exclusion modulo 8, the parity of D_k , the impossibility of $D_k \in \{1, 3\}$, the 4-state carry drift recurrence for all k , the polynomial parity invariant $V_m \bmod 2 \equiv m \bmod 2$, and the defect equivalence) are proven for all $k, m \in \mathbb{N}$. Higher valuation instances of the LTE rigidity theorems and finite-range bounds are formally verified via certified kernel evaluation (`decide`).

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APPENDIX A. FORMAL LEAN 4 THEOREM SIGNATURES

Below are the exact Lean 4 declarations and signatures proven in `TwoAdicDefectRigidity.lean`:

```
-- Division identity & equivalence to Dickson-Pillai condition
theorem div_identity (k : Nat) : 3^k = 2^k * (3^k / 2^k) + (3^k % 2^k)
theorem defect_equiv (k : Nat) : DicksonPillaiCondition k <-> q k <= D k

-- Universal Theorem 1: Residue Exclusion Modulo 8 & Small Defect Impossibility
theorem D_mod_eight (k : Nat) (hk : 3 <= k) : (D k) % 8 = if k % 2 = 0 then 7 else 5
theorem D_ne_one (k : Nat) (hk : 3 <= k) : D k != 1
theorem D_ne_three (k : Nat) (hk : 3 <= k) : D k != 3
theorem D_odd (k : Nat) (hk : 3 <= k) : D k % 2 = 1

-- Universal Theorem 4: Discrete Carry Drift Recurrence
theorem drift_identity (k : Nat) : 3 * (D k : Int) - (D (k + 1) : Int) = C k * (2^k : Int)

-- Theorems 2 & 3: Exact 2-Adic Valuations (LTE instances)
theorem even_rigidity_k6 : (D 6 + 1) % 16 = 8
theorem even_rigidity_k8 : (D 8 + 1) % 64 = 32
theorem even_rigidity_k10 : (D 10 + 1) % 16 = 8
theorem even_rigidity_k16 : (D 16 + 1) % 128 = 64
theorem odd_rigidity_k11 : (D 11 + 3) % 16 = 8
theorem odd_branch_k13 : (D 13 + 3) % 32 = 16
theorem odd_branch_k17 : (D 17 + 3) % 128 = 64

-- Theorem 6: Dynamical Repulsion and Failure Isolation
theorem repulsion_defect_step (D_k : Nat) (two_k : Nat) (hD : 1 <= D_k) : 3 * D_k + two_k > two_k
theorem repulsion_bound_k5 : 2^5 > 2 * q 6
theorem repulsion_even_isolated_k5 (D_k : Nat) (hD : 1 <= D_k) : 3 * D_k + 2^5 > 2 * q 6

-- Section 5.1: Carry Transducer Matrix Spectrum
def charPolyA (x : Int) : Int := -x^4 + x^3 + x^2 - x
theorem char_poly_root_zero : charPolyA 0 = 0
theorem char_poly_root_one : charPolyA 1 = 0
theorem char_poly_root_neg1 : charPolyA (-1) = 0
```

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